

Asia before Colonial Times

Francis Bond

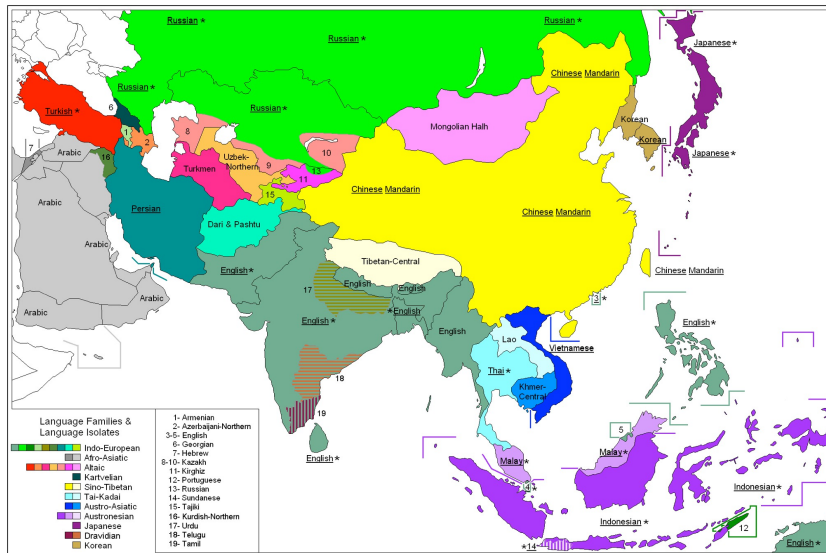
based on slides by František Kratochvíl

2026

Overview

- 1 Language Families of Asia
- 2 Geography and Climate
- 3 Crops and Domestication
- 4 Lexical Borrowing

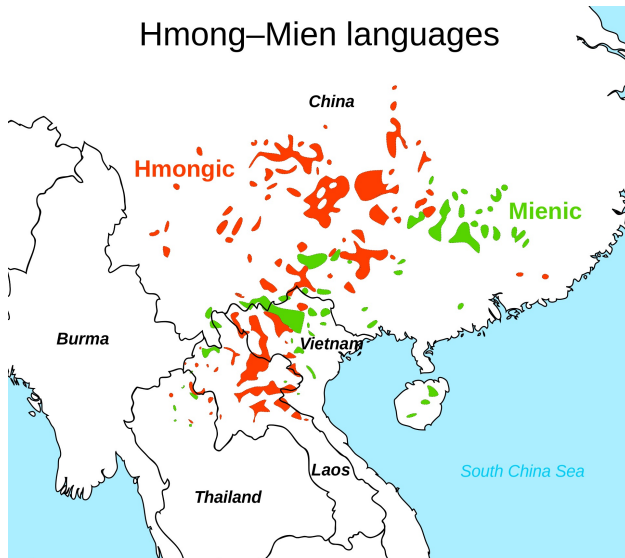
Major languages of Asia



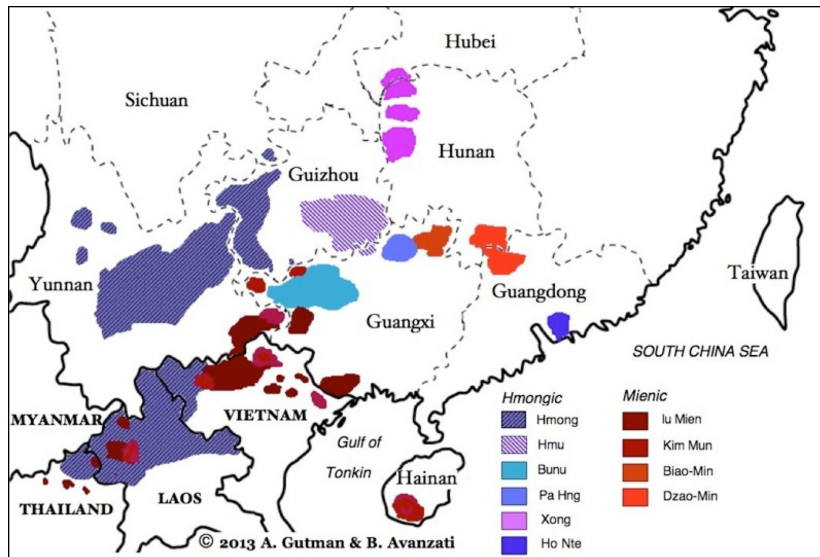
Austro-Asiatic family



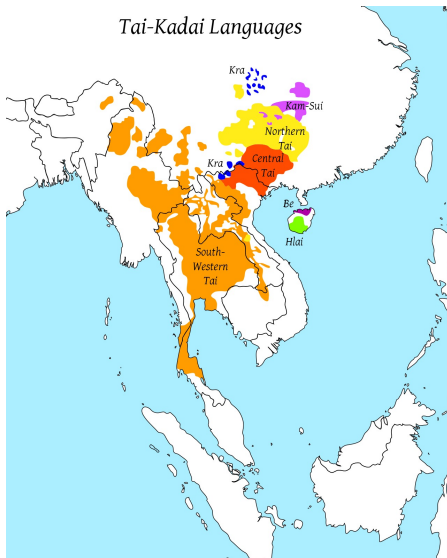
Hmong-Mien family



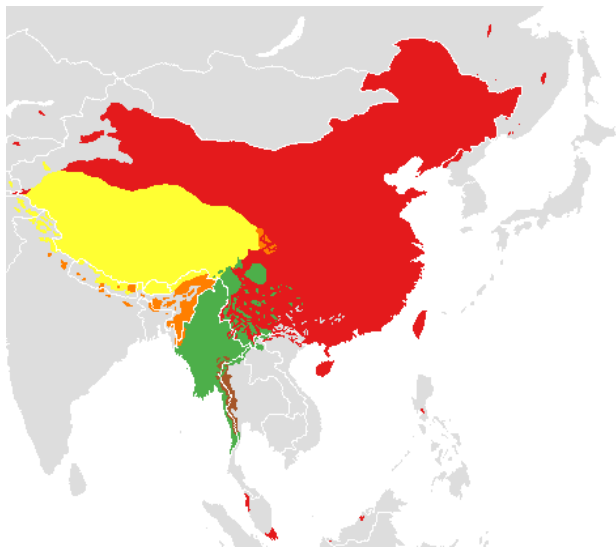
Hmong-Mien family



Tai-Kadai family (probably a branch of Austronesian)

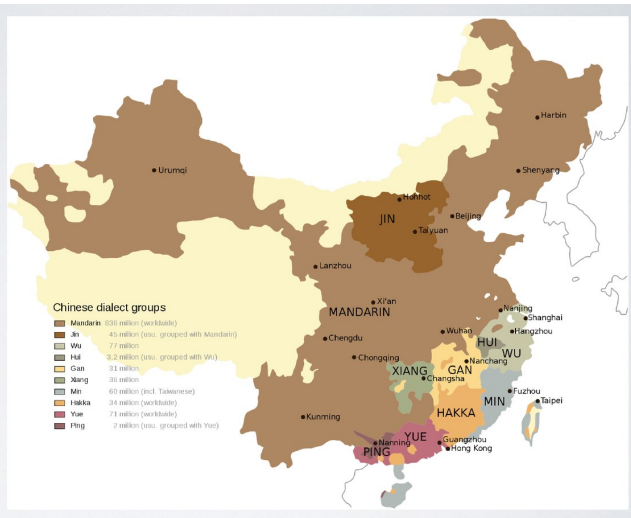


Sino-Tibetan family

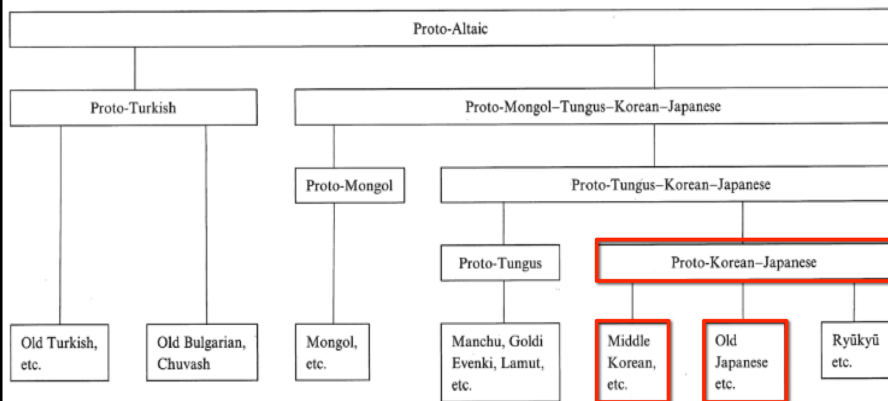


■ Sinitic ■ Tibetic ■ Lolo-Burmese ■ Karenic ■ other (Kuki, Chin, Naga, ...)

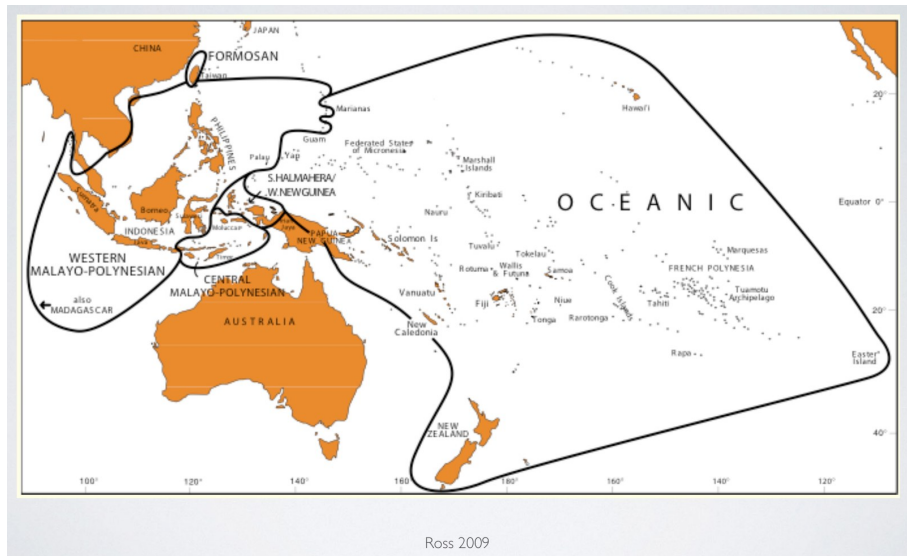
Sinitic branch



Altaic hypothesis



The integrity of the Austronesian language family



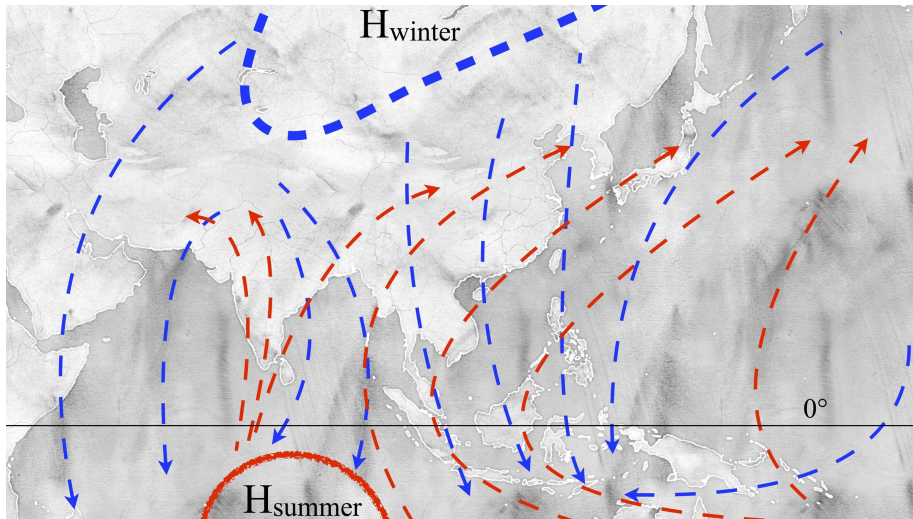
Relief of East and Southeast Asia



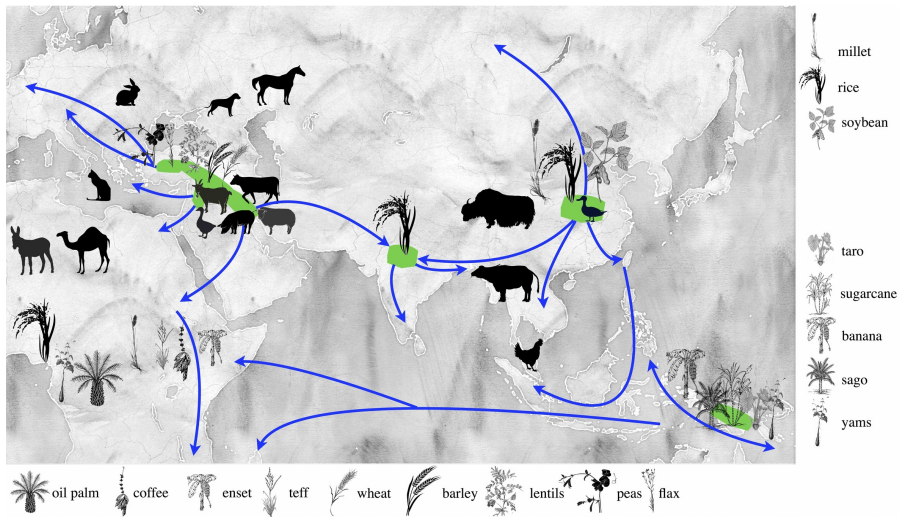
Relief of mainland Southeast Asia



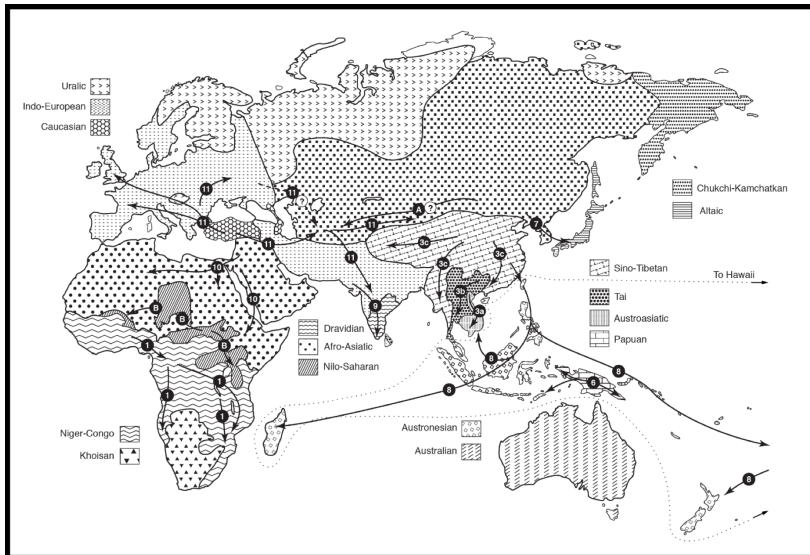
Monsoon patterns



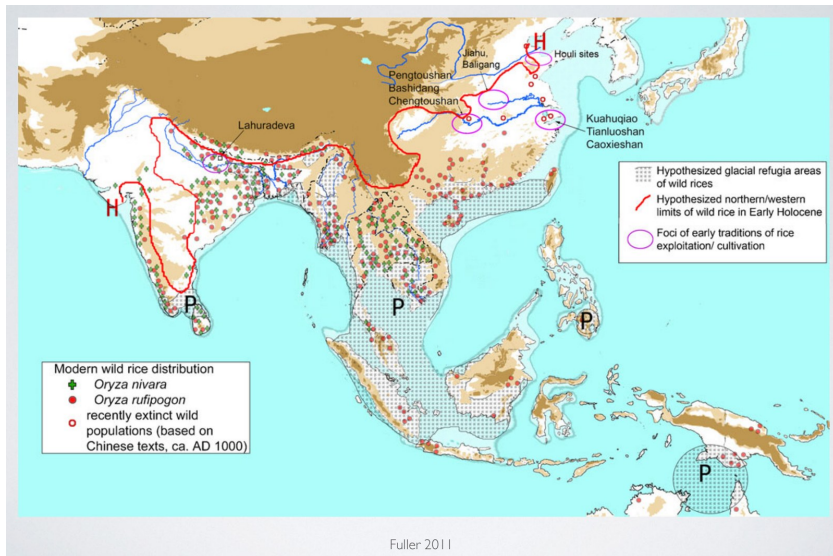
Cultural crops



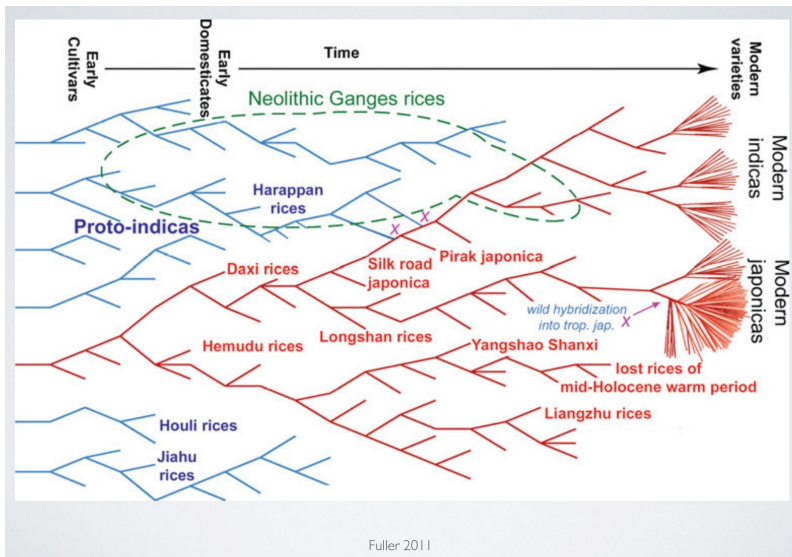
Cultural crops and language family expansions



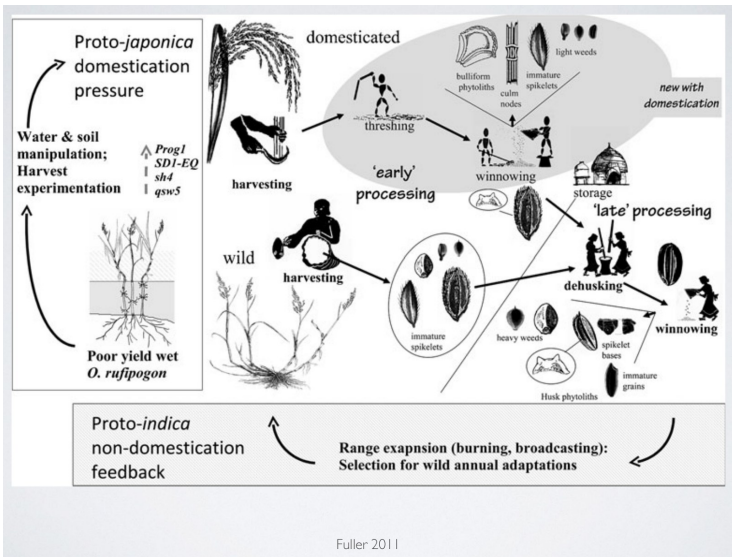
Last glacial period sea levels and natural refugia of wild rice



Genetic diversity of rice

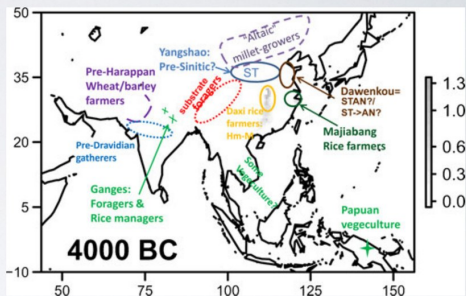
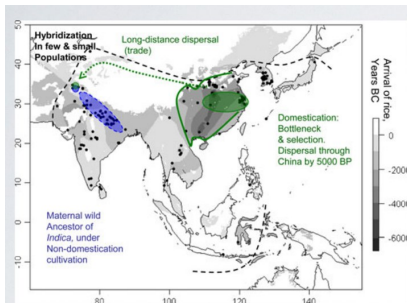


Domestication pressures on rice



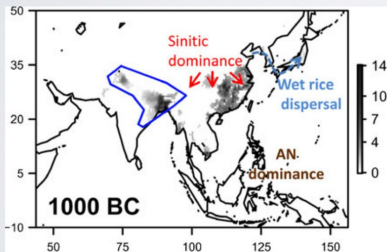
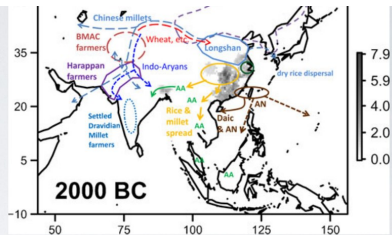
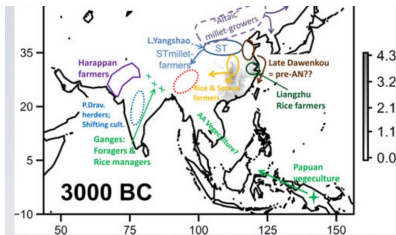
Fuller 2011

Spreading of rice hybrids

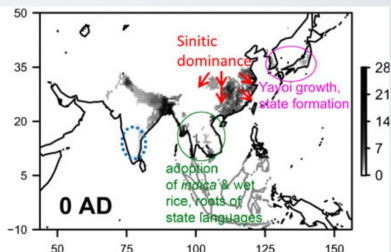


Fuller 2011

Spreading of rice hybrids

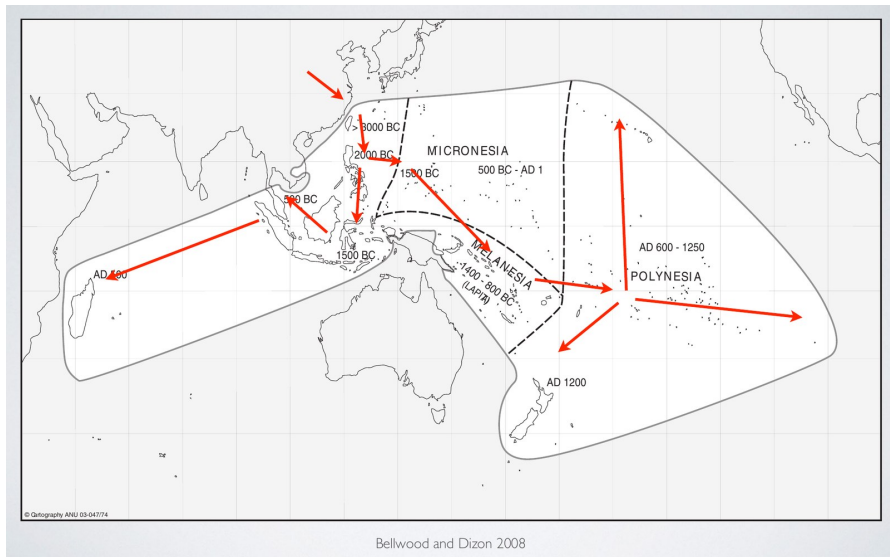


Major population growth
Pushed Indo-Aryan to dominance;
State-formation; Dispersal to Ceylon

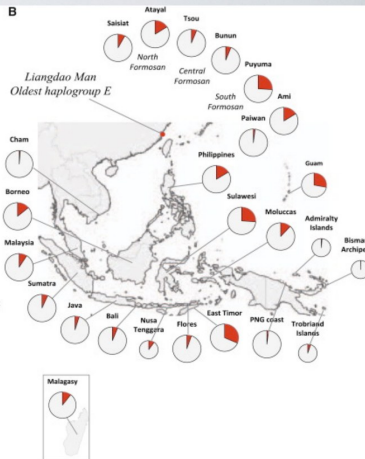
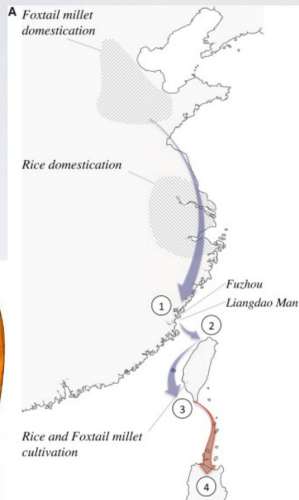
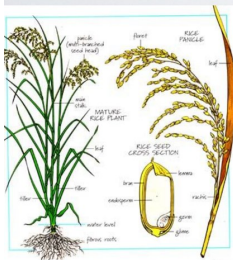


Rice-based Dravidian & Maharati
State-formation

Reconstruction of Austronesian expansion



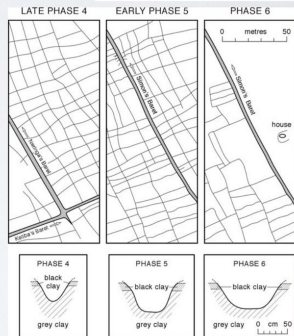
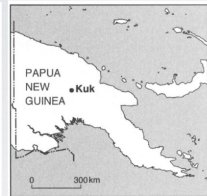
Millets



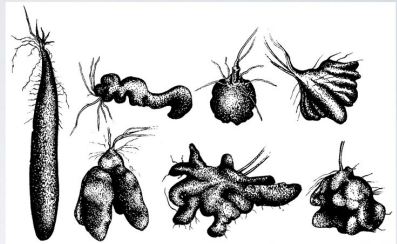
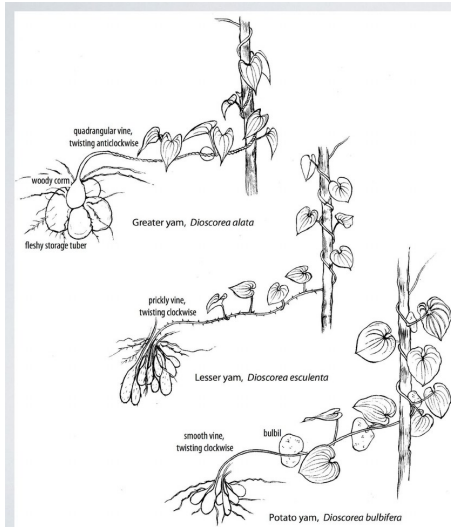
Suggested Migration Route for Early Austronesians Into and Out of Taiwan and the Worldwide Distribution of Haplogroup E1 (A) Geographic regions in China of foxtail millet domestication (source: Ko et al. 2014)

Taro domestication

Multidisciplinary investigations at Kuk Swamp in the Highlands of Papua New Guinea show that agriculture arose independently in New Guinea by at least 6950 to 6440 calibrated years before the present (cal yr B.P.). Plant exploitation and some cultivation occurred on the wetland margin at 10,220 to 9910 cal yr B.P. (phase 1), mounding cultivation began by 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P. (phase 2), and ditched cultivation began by 4350 to 3980 cal yr B.P. (phase 3). Clearance of lower montane rainforests began in the early Holocene, with modification to grassland at 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P. Taro (*Colocasia esculenta*) was utilized in the early Holocene, and bananas (*Musa* spp.) were intensively cultivated by at least 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P.



New Guinean domestications: tubers



Yams (*Dioscorea alata*)

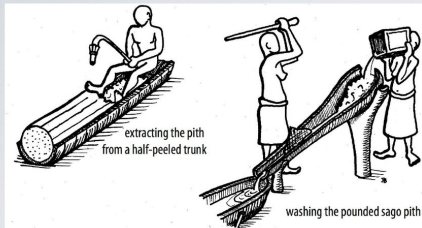


Colocasia

Alocasia

Taro (Araceae) and Amorphophallus

New Guinean domestications: sago



New Guinean domestications: banana



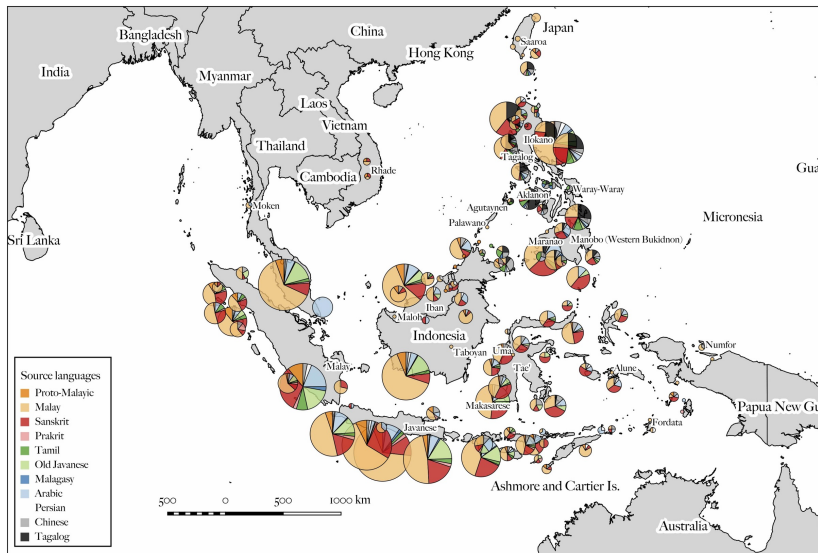
Over 100 new accessions of wild and cultivated bananas were obtained from a wide geographic region including West New Britain, East New Britain, New Ireland, Western Highlands, East Sepik, Madang and Milne Bay



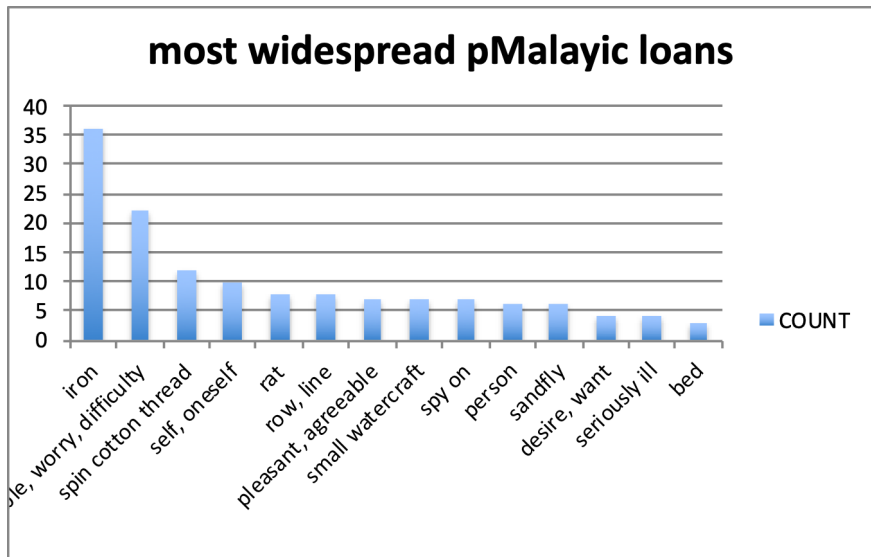
New Guinean domestications: sugar cane



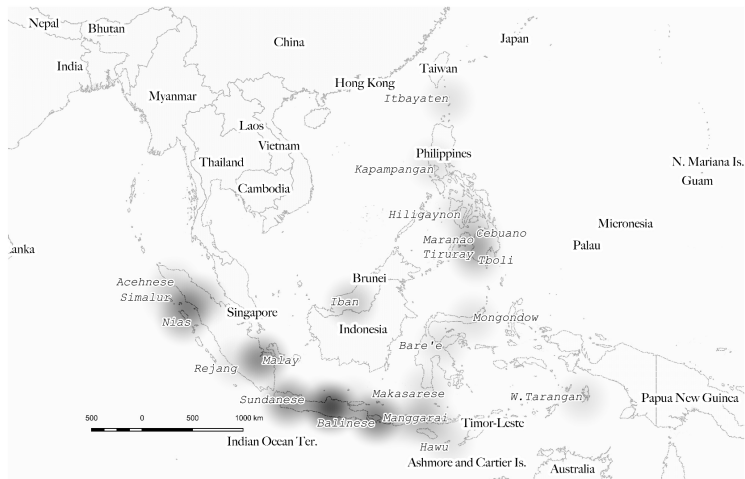
Lexical borrowing in Austronesian



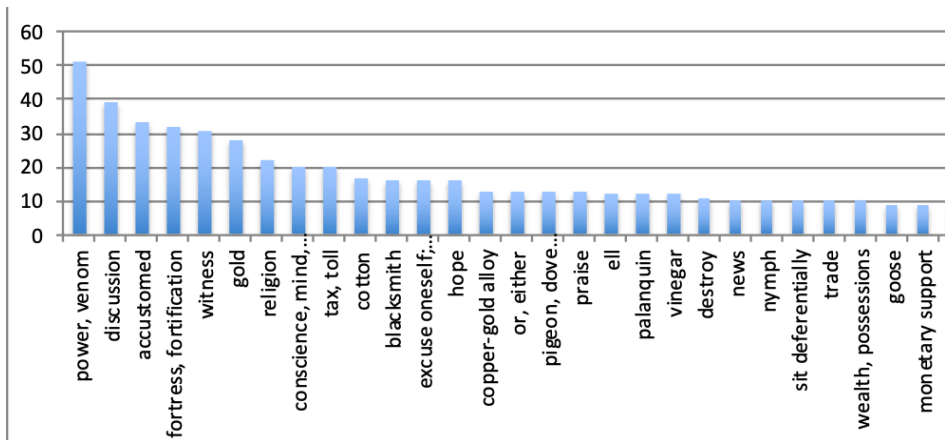
Malayic loanwords



Indic loanwords



Most common Sanskrit loans in languages of SE Asia



Indic loanwords — the 28 most widespread; the tail of another 29 is omitted

Grantha and Pallava scripts

Phoenician	Aramaic	Value	Brahmi	Value
𐤀	𐤁	*	𑀀	a
𐤂	𐤃	b [b]	𑀁	ba
𐤄	𐤅	g [g]	𑀂	ga
𐤆	𐤇	d [d]	𑀃	dha
𐤈	𐤉	h [h], M.L.	𑀄	ha
𐤊	𐤋	w [w], M.L.	𑀅	va
𐤌	𐤍	z [z]	𑀆	ja
𐤏	𐤐	h [h]	𑀇	gha
𐤑	𐤒	t [t]	𑀈	tha
𐤔	𐤕	y [j], M.L.	𑀉	ya
𐤖	𐤗	k [k]	𑀊	ka
𐤙	𐤚	l [l]	𑀋	la
𐤛	𐤜	m [m]	𑀌	ma
𐤞	𐤟	n [n]	𑀍	na
𐤡	𐤢	s [s]	𑀎	sa
𐤤	𐤥	' [ʔ], M.L.	𑀏	e
𐤧	𐤨	p [p]	𑀐	pa
𐤩	𐤪	ś [sʰ]	𑀑	ca
𐤬	𐤭	q [q]	𑀒	kha
𐤮	𐤯	r [r]	𑀓	ra
𐤱	𐤲	ṣ [ʃ]	𑀔	śa
𐤴	𐤵	t [t]	𑀕	ta

Indian scripts are
derived from Greco-
Phoenitian alphabeth

ക	ഖ	ഗ	ഘ	ങ
k	kh	g	gh	ṅ
ച	ഛ	ജ	ഞ	ത
c	ch	j	jh	ṭ
ട	ഠ	ഡ	ഢ	ണ
ṭ	ṭh	ḍ	ḍh	ṇ
ത	ഥ	ഉ	ധ	ന
t	th	d	dh	n
പ	ഫ	ബ	ഭ	മ
p	ph	b	bh	m
യ	ര	ല	വ	റ
y	r	l	v	ṛ
ശ	ഷ	സ	ഹ	
ś	ṣ	s	h	

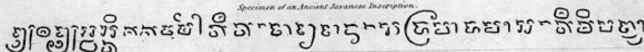
ക	കൃ	ഇ	ഈ	ഉ	ഉഃ
a	ā	i	ī	u	ū
ഋ	ൠ	ൡ	ൢ		
r	ṛ	l	l̄		
ൣ	൤	൥	൦	൦	൦
e	ai	o	au		
൦	ഃ				
m	ḥ				

PALLAVA
SCRIPT

Austronesian scripts derived from Indian

Kawi
(700-1500 AD)

Specimen of an Ancient Javanese Inscription



Alphabets not arranged according to the Demanagri classification.

MODERN JAVANESE ALPHABET.

Open Consonants, which the Vowels a or o are always understood to follow.

ho no cho ro ko do lo so wo lo po de jo vo nvo mo go bo to ngo
 ha na ca ra ka da la sa wa la pa da ja va nva ma ga ba ta nga
 ho no cho ko do to so w lo po do jo nvo mo bo to

Consonants following Consonants, without a Vowel intervening.

ho no cho ko do to so w lo po do jo nvo mo bo to

Contractions of Consonants.

h r r modif y ng
 with the termination
 of a word in a
 consonant

Great Letters used on occasions of Ceremony

no ro so bo go bo

Vowels and orthographical marks

Beginning of a new passage.

Beginning of a stanza.

Period.

Period.

Javanese
(still in use)

Hā Nā Cā Rā Kā

Dā Tā Sā Wā Lā

Mā Gā Bā Ngā

Pā Jā Yā Nyā

Balinese
(still in use)

Cham
(still used)

Consonants

ka kha ga gha ngue nga cha chha ja jha rhue nha nhā
 ta tha da dha nue na dda pa ppa pha ba bha mue ma
 tba ya ra la va ssa sa ya

Vowels

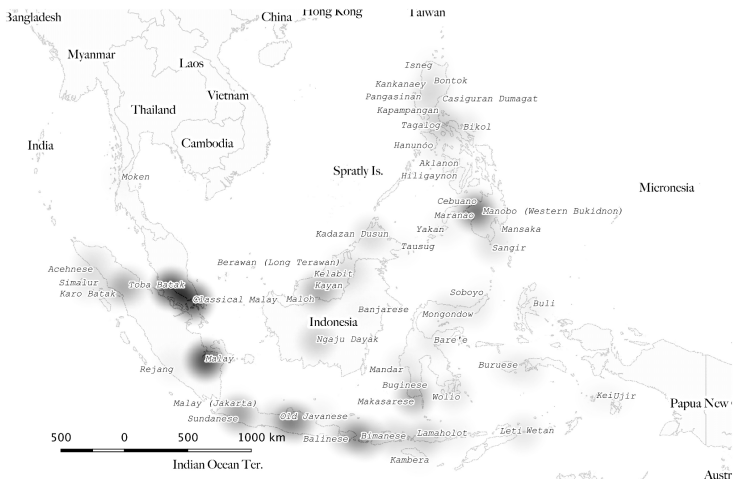
a i u e ai o

Vowel diacritics

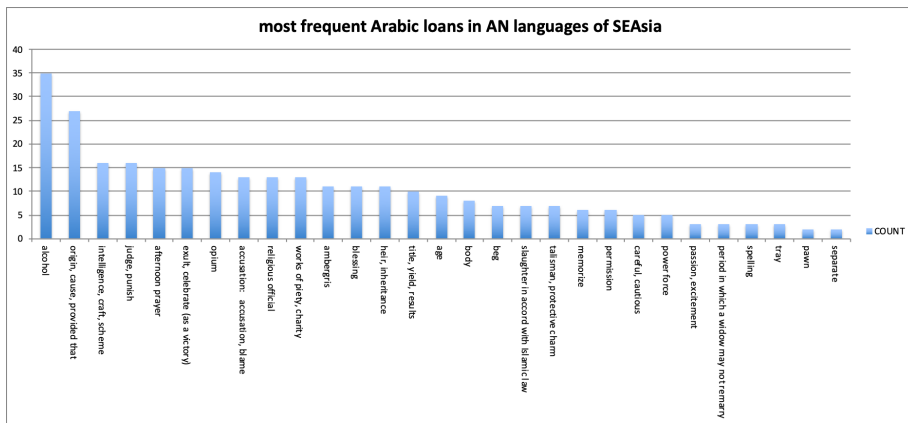
a i li ei u uu oeu oe ooe e

ee o oo ai au ue uue

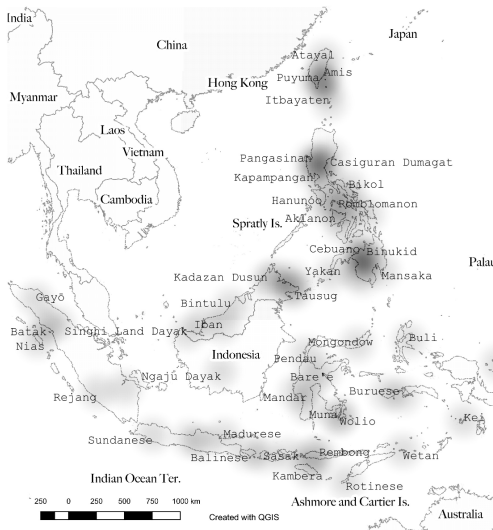
Arabic loanwords



Arabic loanwords

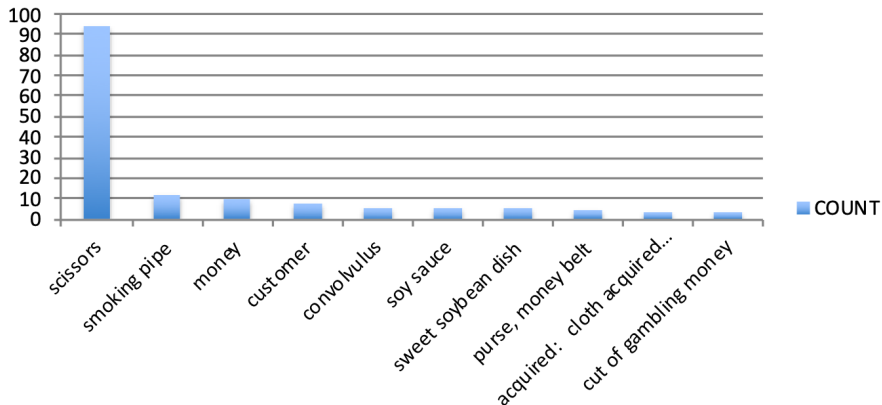


Chinese loanwords

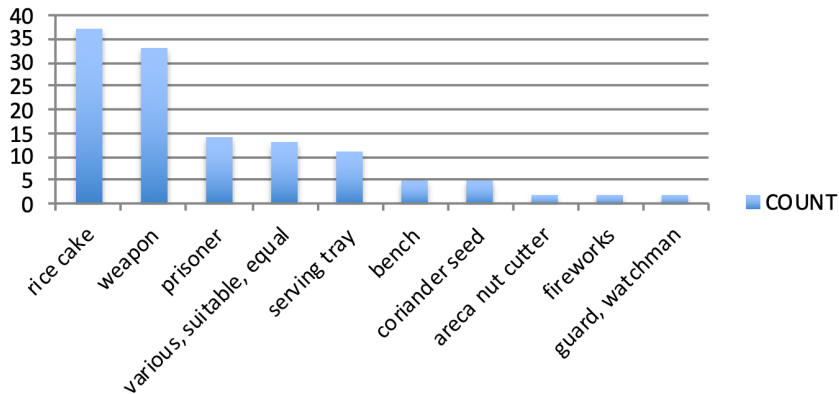


Chinese loanwords

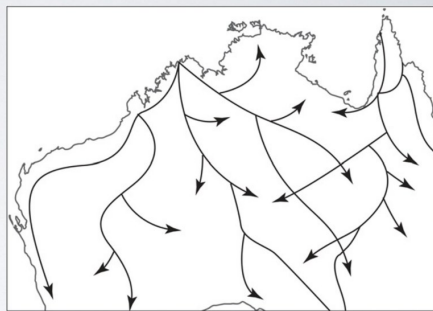
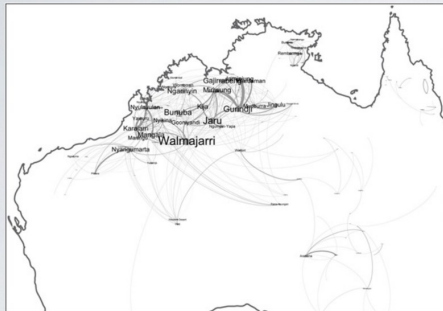
Most widespread Chinese loans



Most common Tamil loans in languages of SEAsia



Wanderwörter in Australian languages



References I

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- Coupe, Alexander R. and František Kratochvíl. 2020. Asia before English. In Kingsley Bolton, Werner Botha and Andy Kirkpatrick (eds.), *The Handbook of Asian Englishes*, 31–59. Wiley. DOI 10.1002/9781118791882.ch2
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- Sather, Clifford. 2006. Sea nomads and rainforest hunter-gatherers: foraging adaptations in the Indo-Malaysian archipelago. In Peter Bellwood (ed.), *The Austronesians: Historical and Comparative Perspectives*, 245–285. Canberra: ANU E Press.
- Fuller, Dorian Q. 2011. Pathways to Asian civilizations: tracing the origins and spread of rice and rice cultures. *Rice* 4: 78–92.
(the source of the rice maps and phylogenies above)

Acknowledgement

- These slides are a re-typeset version of **Asia before Colonial Times** by **František Kratochvíl**, given for *Lingvistika asijských jazyků* (DAS/LAS) on 18 February 2021.
- The figures are his, or are reproduced in his slides from the sources named on each slide and listed at the end.
- Rebuilt here in the format of the rest of the course so that it can be maintained and revised alongside the other weeks. Any errors introduced in the rebuilding are mine.
- The same ground is covered at chapter length, with references, in Coupe & Kratochvíl (2020), *Asia before English* — the reading for this week.
- The Sanskrit-in-many-scripts figure is by Abhay Agarwal, via Wikimedia Commons (*Phrase sanskrit.png*, CC BY-SA 3.0). It is Figure 2.5 of Coupe & Kratochvíl (2020), which credits it the same way.
- Thanks to František for making the material available.